

SSC CGL ENGLISH

SPOTTING ERRORS

RECALL-FIRST MASTER NOTES

36 rules reorganized for fast recognition, exact error location and minimum correction.

THE CORE MENTAL COMMAND

TRIGGER -> TARGET -> RULE -> MINIMUM CHANGE

Pairs + fixed patterns

No sooner->than | hardly->when | either->or | neither->nor | not only->but also

Agreement traps

long subject | there + real subject | relative clause | noun clause | none/neither/either

Verb forms

do/does/did->V1 | modal->V1 | enjoy/worth/object to -> V-ing | allow + object + to V1

Watch rules

first conditional | past perfect | sequence of tenses | articles | possessive | inversion | subjunctive

Use this PDF in two modes: Instant rules = 2-second trigger checks. Hard rules = slow down only long enough to identify the controlled word.

1 | START HERE

The page you should remember before every spotting-errors question.

STEP	ACTION	WHAT YOUR EYES DO
1	FIND THE TRIGGER	every, each, did, modal, if, no sooner, hardly, not only, who, to, rarely...
2	JUMP TO TARGET	Usually the next verb, paired connector, subject, or complement after the trigger.
3	NAME THE RULE	Agreement verb form pair tense article preposition parallelism inversion
4	LOCATE A/B/C/D	Pick the chunk containing the controlled word. Do not scan all four equally.
5	MINIMUM CHANGE	Replace only the faulty word or phrase. Re-read once.

MASTER QUESTION: "Who/what is controlling this word?"

EVERY

Every student know...

CHECK: verb -> knows

DID

She did not went...

CHECK: next verb -> go

NO SOONER

No sooner...when...

CHECK: pair -> than

OBJECT TO

object to change...

CHECK: to is preposition -> changing

ONLY AFTER

Only after... I realised...

CHECK: inversion -> did I realise

A/AN

an university...

CHECK: sound -> a university

START-HERE RECALL LOCK

every / each -> inspect subject + verb

did / does -> next verb -> V1

modal -> next verb -> V1

no sooner -> than

object to -> noun / V-ing

only after -> auxiliary before subject

a/an -> sound check

who / which -> trace to antecedent

CIRCLE

what to notice

JUMP

what to inspect

PROVE

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

Every student know... [answer: knows]

She did not went... [answer: go]

No sooner...when... [answer: than]

2 | INSTANT RECALL ZONE

Pair rules stay together because the first half should automatically make your eyes search for the second half.

NO SOONER	THAN	HARDLY / SCARCELY / BARELY	WHEN
no sooner ... than	CHECK	hardly/scarcely/barely ... when	CHECK
See no sooner -> scan ahead for than.		See any of the three -> scan ahead for when.	
EITHER	OR	NEITHER	NOR
either ... or	CHECK	neither ... nor	CHECK
Pair first; then inspect agreement if needed.		Pair first; then inspect agreement if needed.	
NOT ONLY	BUT ALSO	DO / DOES / DID	V1
not only ... but also	CHECK	do/does/did + V1	CHECK
Pair + compare the two grammatical forms.		The helper carries tense/agreement; next verb returns to base form.	
MODAL	V1	ENJOY / AVOID	V-ING
modal + V1	CHECK	enjoy/avoid + V-ing	CHECK
can/could/may/might/should/will/must -> next verb V1.		Action after these triggers is commonly gerund-form.	
WORTH	V-ING / NOUN	OBJECT TO	NOUN / V-ING
worth + V-ing / noun	CHECK	object to + noun / V-ing	CHECK
Never use the standard "worth to read" pattern.		Here to is a preposition, not an infinitive marker.	
ALLOW + OBJECT	TO + V1	TAKE THE TROUBLE	TO + V1
allow + object + to V1	CHECK	take the trouble to + V1	CHECK
Ask: allow whom? Then check to + V1.		Fixed phrase: trouble to do, not trouble doing.	
IF	PRESENT -> WILL	PAIR MEMORY	THAN / WHEN / OR / NOR / BUT ALSO
if + present, will + V1	CHECK	NO SOONER->THAN HARDLY->WHEN EITHER->OR NEITHER->NOR NOT ONLY->BUT ALSO	CHECK
Standard first conditional: condition in present, result with will.		First half -> hunt for partner.	

PAIR TRAP: A correct connector pair does not guarantee a correct sentence. After the pair check, inspect agreement or parallelism where relevant.

PAIR AUTO-COMPLETE

FIND PAIR	CHECK FORM	STOP
what to notice	what to inspect	what to do
10-SECOND SELF-TEST No sooner had he arrived ____ the meeting began. [answer: than] Hardly had I reached home ____ it started raining. [answer: when] Either you study hard ____ you revise daily. [answer: or]		

2A | PAIRS THAT HIDE A SECOND CHECK

Not only/but also is a classic "pair is correct but sentence is still wrong" trap.

22. NOT ONLY ... BUT ALSO

HARD

not only + X + but also + X

TRIGGER	not only	
FOCUS	The second connector + the forms on both sides.	
IDENTIFY	Circle the unit after not only and the unit after but also; compare adjective/noun/V-ing/to-V forms.	
TRAP	A correct pair can still hide a parallelism error.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
She is not only intelligent but also hardworking.	No error	Adjective + adjective. Pair is correct AND the forms match.
He is not only reading the report but also to check the figures.	to check -> checking	Both are coordinated actions; use the same -ing form.
The manager not only approved the plan but also sent an email.	No error	Verb phrase + verb phrase; both sides match.

23. PARALLELISM

HARD

noun + noun + noun | V-ing + V-ing + V-ing | to V + to V + to V | adjective + adjective

TRIGGER	and / or / but / both...and / not only...but also	
FOCUS	Compare every item joined by the connector.	
IDENTIFY	Circle item 1 and item 2 (and item 3 if present); compare grammatical shape before meaning.	
TRAP	Do not match meaning only; match grammatical form.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
He likes reading, to swim and cycling.	to swim -> swimming	The list is V-ing + to-V + V-ing; make all forms V-ing.
The job requires patience, dedication and to work hard.	to work hard -> hard work	Noun + noun + to-V is not parallel; make all items noun-form.
She wants to learn, to practise and to improve.	No error	to-V + to-V + to-V is fully parallel.

FAST TEST: Circle both sides of the connector. Ask only one question: "Do these items have the same grammatical shape?"

PARALLELISM RECALL LOCK

not only ... but also -> pair + same form	reading / swimming / cycling -> all V-ing
to learn / to practise / to improve -> all to-V	patience / dedication / hard work -> all nouns
intelligent / hardworking -> all adjectives	pair correct? -> still check parallelism

PAIR FIRST

what to notice

COMPARE SHAPES

what to inspect

MINIMUM FIX

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He is not only reading but also ____ the figures. [answer: checking]

He likes reading, to swim and cycling -> change [answer: to swim -> swimming]

She wants to learn, to practise and to improve. [answer: No error]

3 | SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

The easy SVA triggers should be instant. The next pages are only for the traps that need reasoning.

EVERY / EACH	SINGULAR	EITHER / NEITHER	SINGULAR *
every/each + singular noun + singular verb	CHECK	either/neither + singular construction	CHECK
Check the main verb immediately after the subject skeleton.		Do not let a later plural noun distract you.	
EACH OF	SINGULAR	NO ONE / EVERYONE / SOMEONE	SINGULAR
each of + plural noun + singular verb	CHECK	indefinite pronoun + singular verb	CHECK
Ignore the plural noun inside the of-phrase.		Meaning may be many people; grammar remains singular.	

*In either/neither, always inspect the actual construction; the source specifically warns against a blanket rule.

4. NONE / NEITHER / EITHER

HARD

Identify the construction before choosing the verb.

TRIGGER	none / neither / either	
FOCUS	Who is the grammatical subject? What follows?	
IDENTIFY	Remove "of + noun" mentally, identify the head, then choose agreement.	
TRAP	Do not force "none = singular" in every sentence.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
Neither of the answers are correct.	are -> is	Neither is the head; answers is inside the of-phrase.
None of the information were useful.	were -> was	Information is uncountable here; the intended construction takes singular agreement.
Either of the two options works.	No error	Either can be the singular head in this construction.

SVA SPEED RECALL

EVERY / EACH -> singular	EACH OF + plural -> singular verb
NO ONE / EVERYONE / SOMEONE -> singular	EITHER / NEITHER -> check construction
NONE -> inspect actual head	plural after of -> often a distractor

FIND HEAD

what to notice

MATCH NUMBER

what to inspect

CHECK VERB

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

Each of the students ___ ready. [answer: is]

Everyone in the room ___ the answer. [answer: knows]

Neither of the answers ___ correct. [answer: is]

3A | AGREEMENT LAB

Three traps: long subjects, there-constructions, relative clauses and noun clauses. Use an operation, not intuition.

5. LONG SUBJECTS: IGNORE THE MIDDLE

HARD

The quality [of the products] has improved.

TRIGGER	of / with / along with / together with / as well as	
FOCUS	Find the head noun before the distracting phrase.	
IDENTIFY	Delete the middle phrase mentally: "The quality has improved."	
TRAP	Nearest noun is not automatically the subject.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
The quality of the products have improved.	have -> has	Head = quality. Delete "of the products" -> The quality has improved.
The list of selected candidates is on the desk.	No error	Head = list. The plural candidates is inside the middle phrase.
The results of the new survey shows a clear trend.	shows -> show	Head = results. Delete the middle -> The results show...

6. THERE IS / THERE ARE

HARD

There + verb + real subject -> agreement follows the real subject

TRIGGER	there is / there are	
FOCUS	Look immediately to the noun after the verb.	
IDENTIFY	Remove "there" and rebuild the skeleton: "Many reasons are..."	
TRAP	Do not choose is/are by intuition before looking at the following noun.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
There is many reasons for the delay.	is -> are	Real subject = many reasons (plural).
There are a problem with the report.	are -> is	Real subject = a problem (singular).
There are several reasons to postpone the meeting.	No error	Real subject = several reasons (plural).

AGREEMENT OPERATIONS

LONG SUBJECT -> delete the middle	quality of products have -> quality has
results of survey shows -> results show	THERE IS / ARE -> find real subject
There is many reasons -> Many reasons are	There are a problem -> A problem is

DELETE MIDDLE

what to notice

FIND REAL SUBJECT

what to inspect

MATCH VERB

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

The list of selected candidates ____ on the desk. [answer: is]

There ____ several reasons. [answer: are]

The quality of the products ____ improved. [answer: has]

3B | AGREEMENT LAB

Relative clauses and noun clauses become manageable when you trace the subject instead of the nearest noun.

7. RELATIVE CLAUSE: MATCH THE VERB WITH THE ANTECEDENT

HARD

who / which / that -> antecedent -> agreement

TRIGGER	who / which / that	
FOCUS	Which noun does the relative pronoun refer to?	
IDENTIFY	Draw a mental arrow: who/which/that -> antecedent, then match the relative-clause verb.	
TRAP	The "one of + plural noun + who..." pattern needs careful antecedent reading.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
He is one of the players who plays regularly.	plays -> play	In the intended "players who..." reading, who refers to players (plural).
She is the only one of the students who works on Sundays.	No error	Here who can refer to "the only one"; singular works in the intended reading.
The students who was selected for the interview arrived early.	was -> were	who -> students -> plural, so were.

8. NOUN CLAUSE AS SUBJECT

HARD

[What he said] was unexpected.

TRIGGER	what / that / how / why clause at the start	
FOCUS	Ask what the subject of the main clause is.	
IDENTIFY	Put brackets around the whole clause, then treat the unit as singular for the main verb.	
TRAP	Do not let a plural noun inside the clause control the outside verb.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
What he said were completely unexpected.	were -> was	[What he said] is one subject unit -> was.
Why she left the job remains unclear.	No error	The whole why-clause is the singular subject unit.
That the report was delayed has worried the manager.	No error	The that-clause is one subject unit; has is correct.

ANTECEDENT + CLAUSE LOCK

who / which / that -> trace backward	students who was -> who -> students -> were
one of the players who... -> ask what who refers to	[What he said] -> one subject unit
Why she left... -> whole clause -> singular	plural inside clause -> does not control outside verb

ARROW BACK

what to notice

BRACKET CLAUSE

what to inspect

MATCH MAIN VERB

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

The students who ____ selected arrived early. [answer: were]

What he said ____ unexpected. [answer: was]

Why she left the job ____ unclear. [answer: remains]

4 | VERB FORM

These are the fastest marks: spot the helper, then inspect the next verb.

DO / DOES / DID	V1	MODAL	V1
do/does/did + V1	CHECK	can/could/may/might/should/will/must + V1	CHECK
did go, not did went.		Never add -s or -ed after a modal.	
ENJOY / AVOID	V-ING	WORTH	V-ING / NOUN
enjoy/avoid + V-ing	CHECK	worth + V-ing / noun	CHECK
Action after the trigger -> gerund.		Avoid the standard "worth to read" pattern.	
ALLOW + OBJECT	TO + V1	TAKE THE TROUBLE	TO + V1
allow + object + to V1	CHECK	take the trouble to + V1	CHECK
Ask "allow whom?" then check to + V1.		Fixed phrase: trouble to do.	

2-SECOND ROUTINE: do/does/did -> look one verb right. Modal -> look one verb right. Enjoy/worth -> look at the following action. Allow -> find the object, then to + V1.

VERB-FORM AUTO-PILOT

did + -> V1	does + -> V1
modal + -> V1	enjoy / avoid + -> V-ing
worth + -> V-ing / noun	allow + object + -> to + V1
take the trouble + -> to + V1	->

SEE HELPER	LOOK ONE VERB	USE V1 / V-ING
what to notice	what to inspect	what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He did not ____ there. [answer: go]

She can ____ English. [answer: speak]

The teacher allowed students ____ early. [answer: to leave]

5 | TENSE & CONDITIONALS

Unlike pair rules, these require a tiny timeline. Do not solve them mechanically.

15. FIRST CONDITIONAL

WATCH

If + present simple, will + V1

TRIGGER	if	
FOCUS	Check the verb inside the if-clause first.	
IDENTIFY	For a real/possible future condition, present after if; result clause normally uses will + V1.	
TRAP	Do not mechanically put will after if in the standard pattern.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
If it will rain, we will stay home.	will rain -> rains	See if -> inspect its verb first: present simple in the condition.
If you study hard, you will pass the exam.	No error	Present condition + future result.
If the weather improves, we will continue the journey.	No error	Standard first conditional.

16. PAST PERFECT: EARLIER OF TWO PAST ACTIONS

HARD

Earlier event -> had + V3; later event -> simple past when explicit anteriority needs marking.

TRIGGER	two past actions / before / by the time / after	
FOCUS	Build the order of events.	
IDENTIFY	Draw a tiny arrow: earlier -> later. Put had + V3 on the earlier event when the sentence needs it.	
TRAP	Do not insert had mechanically when sequence is already clear.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
When I reached the station, the train left.	left -> had left	Train left before my arrival: earlier event = had left.
By the time the police arrived, the thief had escaped.	No error	Escape happened first; past perfect marks the earlier event.
After she had finished the work, she went home.	No error	Finish happened before going home.

TENSE DECISION LOCK

IF -> present -> will	condition -> inspect if-clause first
two past actions -> build order	earlier event -> had + V3 when needed
later event -> simple past	do not add had -> mechanically

SEE IF / BEFORE what to notice	BUILD ORDER what to inspect	PLACE TENSE what to do
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10-SECOND SELF-TEST

If it ____, we will stay home. [answer: rains]
When I reached, the train ____ earlier. [answer: had left]
By the time police arrived, thief ____ escaped. [answer: had]

5A | SEQUENCE OF TENSES

Meaning decides whether backshift is required. Universal truths are a major loophole.

17. SEQUENCE OF TENSES

HARD

Past report -> often backshift; universal/still-true fact -> present may remain.

TRIGGER	said / told / reported + past reporting verb	
FOCUS	Check whether the dependent statement is being backshifted and whether it remains true now.	
IDENTIFY	Ask: ordinary past report or still-valid/general truth?	
TRAP	Do not force every dependent verb into the past.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
He said that he is tired.	is -> was (when backshift is intended)	Past reporting verb commonly triggers backshift.
The teacher said that the Earth moves around the Sun.	No error	Universal truth can stay in the present.
She told me that she had finished the work before I arrived.	No error	The finishing was earlier than the later past event.

TIMELINE CHECK: Earlier -> had + V3 | Later -> V2. Reported speech -> usually backshift, but universal truth can stay present.

SEQUENCE OF TENSES RECALL

said / told / reported -> check backshift	ordinary past report -> often backshift
universal truth -> present may remain	finished before arrived -> had + V3
meaning first -> not a blind rule	->

SEE REPORT

what to notice

ASK: STILL TRUE?

what to inspect

BACKSHIFT IF NEEDED

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He said that he ___ tired. [answer: was (when backshift intended)]

Earth ___ around the Sun. [answer: moves]

She told me she ___ finished before I arrived. [answer: had]

6 | CONNECTOR MEANING

These are meaning-first rules. Do not over-correct a sentence just because you see when/while/until/unless.

24. WHEN / WHILE

WATCH

while often introduces an ongoing/simultaneous action; when is broader.

TRIGGER	when / while	
FOCUS	Check the time relationship of the two actions.	
IDENTIFY	Ask "what happened during what?" Keep a correct continuous form.	
TRAP	A continuous form is not automatically an error.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
While I was walking, I saw an accident.	No error	Ongoing walking + shorter seeing event during it.
When the teacher entered, the students became quiet.	No error	Simple past correctly shows two completed events in sequence.
While the manager was speaking, the phone rang.	No error	Ongoing speaking + short interrupting event.

25. UNTIL / UNLESS

HARD

UNTIL = up to the time that | UNLESS = if not

TRIGGER	until / unless	
FOCUS	Ask: time boundary or condition?	
IDENTIFY	Translate mentally: unless = if not; until = up to the time.	
TRAP	Do not substitute one connector for the other merely because both join clauses.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
Wait unless I return.	unless -> until	"Wait up to the time I return" = time boundary.
Unless you study, you will not improve.	No error	Unless = if not.
Do not leave until I return.	No error	Until marks the time boundary.

MEANING TEST: WHILE = ongoing/background | WHEN = event/time | UNTIL = time boundary | UNLESS = condition (if not).

MEANING-FIRST CONNECTORS

WHILE -> ongoing / background	WHEN -> event / time
UNTIL -> time boundary	UNLESS -> if not
continuous form -> not automatically wrong	connector choice -> depends on meaning

ASK: TIME?

what to notice

ASK: CONDITION?

what to inspect

CHOOSE CONNECTOR

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

Wait ___ I return. [answer: until]

___ you study, you will not improve. [answer: Unless]

While I ___ walking, I saw an accident. [answer: was]

7 | NOUNS & DETERMINERS

Ask two things: Is it singular + countable? Is the noun normally uncountable?

26. A / AN + SINGULAR COUNTABLE NOUN

HARD

A singular countable noun normally needs a determiner in this new/non-specific use.

TRIGGER	singular countable noun	
FOCUS	Find the noun and ask "one of what?" Then check a/an/the/another/this etc.	
IDENTIFY	Decide a/an by sound, not by spelling.	
TRAP	Do not use bare singular countable nouns in this use.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
He bought book yesterday.	book -> a book	Singular countable, new reference -> a book.
She is an university student.	an -> a	University begins with /yu/ sound -> a university.
He met a honest officer.	a -> an	Honest begins with a vowel sound because h is silent.

27. UNCOUNTABLE NOUNS

HARD

advice / information / furniture / luggage / equipment are typically uncountable.

TRIGGER	advice / information / furniture / luggage / equipment	
FOCUS	Check whether the noun normally forms a plural with -s.	
IDENTIFY	Use some/much/a piece of/etc. rather than an -s plural.	
TRAP	Advices, informations, equipments are common SSC traps.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
She gave me several advices.	advices -> pieces of advice / some advice	Count the pieces, not the word advice.
We need more information before deciding.	No error	Information is uncountable in standard usage.
The company purchased new equipment.	No error	Equipment is normally uncountable.

COUNTABILITY + ARTICLE LOCK

singular + countable -> needs determiner in this use

A / AN -> sound decides

university -> a

honest -> an

advice -> uncountable

information / equipment -> normally no plural -s

COUNT?

what to notice

SOUND?

what to inspect

PLURAL -S?

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He bought ___ book yesterday. [answer: a]

She is ___ university student. [answer: a]

She gave me several _____. [answer: pieces of advice]

7A | WORD FORM

Recognition rules: identify what the word modifies; meaning rules: identify what the word means; case rules: identify the owner.

28. ADJECTIVE vs ADVERB

WATCH

Noun -> adjective | action -> adverb in the relevant construction

TRIGGER	word after a verb / before a noun	
FOCUS	Ask: "What is this word modifying?"	
IDENTIFY	If it modifies a noun -> adjective; if it describes how an action is done -> adverb.	
TRAP	Do not decide from the suffix alone.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
He completed the task quick.	quick -> quickly	The word describes how he completed the action.
She is a quick learner.	No error	Quick modifies the noun learner.
He solved the problem carefully.	No error	Carefully describes the action.

29. PRINCIPAL vs PRINCIPLE

WATCH

principal = head / main | principle = rule / belief

TRIGGER	principal / principle	
FOCUS	Identify the meaning, not the sound.	
IDENTIFY	Head/main -> principal. Rule/belief -> principle.	
TRAP	Similar spelling is the trap.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
The school principle addressed the students.	principle -> principal	A school head is the principal.
Honesty is an important principle of good leadership.	No error	Principle = rule/belief.
The principal reason for the delay was traffic.	No error	Principal = main/most important.

WORD-FORM RECALL

verb action -> -> adverb in relevant use

noun -> -> adjective

principal -> head / main

principle -> rule / belief

meaning check -> not spelling only

->

WHAT IS MODIFIED?

what to notice

MEANING?

what to inspect

CHOOSE FORM

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He completed the task _____. [answer: quickly]

The school ____ addressed students. [answer: principal]

Honesty is an important _____. [answer: principle]

7B | POSSESSIVE CASE

Think in three moves: OWNER -> APOSTROPHE POSITION -> NOUN.

30. POSSESSIVE -S

HARD

singular -> 's | regular plural ending in s -> s' | irregular plural -> 's

TRIGGER	owner + noun	
FOCUS	Find the owner and ask whether it is singular, regular plural, or irregular plural.	
IDENTIFY	Rahul -> Rahul's; boys -> boys'; children -> children's.	
TRAP	Do not treat every of-phrase as an automatic error; the tested issue is a clear possessive construction.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
This is Rahul book.	Rahul book -> Rahul's book	Singular name showing possession takes 's.
The boys room is upstairs.	boys room -> boys' room	Regular plural ending in s -> add apostrophe after s.
The children toys were scattered everywhere.	children toys -> children's toys	Irregular plural -> 's.

MEMORY: ONE BOY -> boy's | MANY BOYS -> boys' | MANY CHILDREN -> children's.

POSSESSIVE APOSTROPHE LOCK

singular owner -> owner's	regular plural ending s -> s'
irregular plural -> 's	Rahul + book -> Rahul's book
boys + room -> boys' room	children + toys -> children's toys

FIND OWNER	CHECK NUMBER	PLACE APOSTROPHE
what to notice	what to inspect	what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

This is Rahul ____ book. [answer: Rahul's]
The boys ____ room is upstairs. [answer: boys']
The children ____ toys were scattered. [answer: children's]

8 | PREPOSITION & COMPLEMENTATION

This is the section where the word "to" can mislead you. Always identify what follows it.

31. OBJECT TO + NOUN / GERUND

HARD

object to + NOUN | object to + V-ing

TRIGGER	object to	
FOCUS	Here to is a preposition, not an infinitive marker.	
IDENTIFY	After object to: noun = correct; action = V-ing. Ask "object to what?"	
TRAP	Do not apply the generic "to + V1" rule here.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
I object to change the plan.	change -> changing	Action after prepositional to -> gerund.
The residents objected to the proposal.	No error	A noun can follow the preposition to.
She objects to working late.	No error	Object to + V-ing.

32. NEED TO / NEED FOR / IN NEED OF

HARD

need to + V1 | need for + noun | in need of + noun

TRIGGER	need	
FOCUS	First decide whether what follows is an action or a noun.	
IDENTIFY	Action -> to + V1. Noun -> for + noun. Need-state -> in need of + noun.	
TRAP	Do not confuse "for + verb" with "to + V1".	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
We need for improve the system.	for improve -> to improve	Improve is an action verb -> need to improve.
There is a need for improvement.	No error	Need for + noun; improvement is a noun.
The machine is in need of repair.	No error	In need of + noun.

TO-TEST: object to + action -> V-ing. But ordinary infinitive -> to + V1. First identify the construction; then choose the form.

TO-COMPLEMENT CHECK

object to + noun -> correct	object to + action -> V-ing
need to + -> V1	need for + -> noun
in need of + -> noun	to is not always infinitive -> identify construction first

SEE TO / NEED

what to notice

NAME COMPLEMENT

what to inspect

CHOOSE FORM

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

I object to ____ the plan. [answer: changing]

We need ____ improve the system. [answer: to]

There is a need for _____. [answer: improvement]

9 | ADVANCED IDENTIFICATION

These rules are hard because the trigger can be far from the error. Use one fixed operation for each.

33. WHO / WHICH / THAT

HARD

Person -> who | thing -> which | that can work in permitted constructions

TRIGGER	who / which / that	
FOCUS	Identify the antecedent and whether it is a person or thing.	
IDENTIFY	Trace the pronoun backward to its antecedent before choosing.	
TRAP	Do not choose based only on the nearest word.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
The man which helped me was kind.	which -> who	Man = person -> who.
The book which I bought is useful.	No error	Book = thing -> which.
The employee who joined yesterday is in my team.	No error	Employee = person -> who.

34. INVERSION AFTER NEGATIVE / RESTRICTIVE EXPRESSIONS

HARD

Rarely + auxiliary + subject + main verb

TRIGGER	rarely / seldom / hardly / only after at the beginning	
FOCUS	Look at word order, not only tense.	
IDENTIFY	If a negative/restrictive adverbial opens the sentence, check for auxiliary before subject.	
TRAP	"Rarely I have seen" needs inversion in the formal structure.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
Rarely I have seen such courage.	I have seen -> have I seen	Opening restrictive adverb -> move auxiliary before subject.
Only after the exam ended I realised the mistake.	I realised -> did I realise	Only after at the beginning -> did + I + realise.
Seldom does he make such mistakes.	No error	Inversion + base verb after does is correct.

ADVANCED 3-STEP OPERATION

WHO / WHICH / THAT -> trace antecedent	person -> who
thing -> which	rarely / seldom -> auxiliary before subject
only after -> auxiliary before subject	one opening trigger -> one controlled target

TRACE / INVERT

what to notice

MOVE AUXILIARY

what to inspect

BASE FORM

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

The man ____ helped me was kind. [answer: who]

Rarely ____ I seen such courage. [answer: have]

Only after the exam ended ____ I realise. [answer: did]

9A | MANDATIVE / SUBJUNCTIVE

Look at the verb inside the that-clause, not at the subject he/she/it.

35. PRESENT SUBJUNCTIVE / MANDATIVE STRUCTURES

HARD

recommend/suggest/essential/important + that + base form; should + V1 if should is retained

TRIGGER	recommended / suggested / essential / important + that	
FOCUS	Check the verb inside the that-clause.	
IDENTIFY	Mandative subjunctive -> base form. If should appears -> should + V1.	
TRAP	Do not add -s merely because the subject is he/she.	
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK
The committee recommended that he submits the form.	submits -> submit	Mandative that-clause uses base form submit.
It is essential that every member be present.	No error	Base-form be is correct in the mandative structure.
The doctor suggested that she should take the medicine.	No error	Should + V1 -> should take.

MEMORY: recommend that he submit | essential that he be | should he take. Never add -s after the mandative trigger or modal should.

BASE-FORM / SUBJUNCTIVE LOCK

recommend that he -> submit	essential that he -> be
should + -> V1	he/she does not force -> -s
that-clause -> inspect inside verb	->

SEE MANDATIVE

what to notice

CHECK THAT-CLAUSE

what to inspect

USE BASE FORM

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

The committee recommended that he _____. [answer: submit]

It is essential that every member _____. [answer: be]

She should _____ the medicine. [answer: take]

10 | EXAM EXECUTION

Minimum change + exact A/B/C/D location. Once you prove the error, stop.

36. MINIMUM-CHANGE PRINCIPLE

HARD

Find the smallest faulty unit -> change only that unit -> reread

TRIGGER	one clear grammatical trigger		
FOCUS	Find the controlled word and test only it.		
IDENTIFY	Circle trigger -> draw arrow -> locate A/B/C/D chunk -> make one minimum correction.		
TRAP	Do not rewrite correct words just to make the sentence sound different.		
EXAMPLE	FIX	WHY / WHERE TO LOOK	
He does not likes coffee.	likes -> like	Does carries tense/agreement; only the main verb is faulty.	
She can speaks English fluently.	speaks -> speak	Modal can requires base form.	
Each of the students are ready.	are -> is	Each is the head; do not change students inside the of-phrase.	

TRIGGER	TARGET	RULE
every / each / either / neither	main subject + verb	agreement
of + plural noun	head noun + main verb	nearest-noun trap
do / does / did	next verb -> V1	verb form
modal	next verb -> V1	verb form
no sooner	later pair -> than	connector
hardly / scarcely / barely	later pair -> when	connector
not only	but also + parallel form	pair + parallelism
if	if-clause tense	conditional
who / which / that	antecedent + relative verb	relative clause
object to / need	complement after trigger	preposition / complementation
rarely / seldom / only after	auxiliary position	inversion

EXAM EXECUTION LOCK

trigger -> circle it	target -> draw one arrow
A/B/C/D -> pick controlled chunk	proof -> state why
minimum change -> fix only faulty unit	re-read -> one final check

CIRCLE TRIGGER

what to notice

DRAW ARROW

what to inspect

ONE MINIMUM CHANGE

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

He does not likes coffee. [answer: likes -> like]

She can speaks English. [answer: speaks -> speak]

Each of the students are ready. [answer: are -> is]

11 | ONE-PAGE RAPID REVISION

Read aloud. Do not recite definitions; train your eyes to jump from trigger to target.

SVA

Every/each/either/neither -> singular in the relevant construction. Ignore distracting of + plural noun.

LONG SUBJECT

Delete the middle phrase. The head noun controls the verb.

THERE

Find the real subject after there.

RELATIVE

who/which/that -> trace back to antecedent -> check agreement/type.

HELPER

do/does/did + V1; modal + V1.

GERUND

enjoy/avoid/worth/object to -> action in V-ing in the relevant pattern.

INFINITIVE

allow + object + to V1; take the trouble to V1.

CONDITIONAL

if + present -> will + V1.

PAST PERFECT

earlier past -> had + V3 when explicit anteriority needs marking.

PAIRS

no sooner-thAn | hardly/scarcely/barely-whEn | either-or | neither-nor | not only-but also

PARALLEL

joined items should match grammatical form.

A/AN

singular countable -> determiner; sound decides a/an.

UNCOUNTABLE

advice/information/equipment etc. -> normally no plural -s.

POSSESSIVE

singular -> 's | regular plural in s -> s' | irregular plural -> 's.

NEED

need to + V1 | need for + noun | in need of + noun.

INVERSION

rarely/seldom/only after at the beginning -> auxiliary before subject.

SUBJUNCTIVE

recommend/suggest/essential + that + base form; should + V1 if should is present.

MINIMUM CHANGE

Correct only the smallest faulty unit.

FINAL MENTAL COMMAND: Trigger -> Target -> Rule -> Minimum change

RAPID REVISION: SAY IT ALOUD

SVA -> find head

PAIR -> find partner

HELPER -> V1

GERUND -> V-ing where required

A/AN -> sound

POSSESSIVE -> owner -> apostrophe

NEED -> action vs noun

INVERSION -> auxiliary before subject

SAY FORMULA

what to notice

RECALL TRAP

what to inspect

MOVE ON

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

No sooner -> [answer: than]

Object to + action -> [answer: V-ing]

Only after -> [answer: aux + subject]

12 | HOW TO TURN THE PDF INTO SPEED

Do not reread all 36 rules every day. Cycle them in layers.

ROUND	WHAT TO DO	EXAMPLE / REMINDER
ROUND 1 - RECOGNITION	Read only the trigger. Say the formula aloud.	"No sooner" -> "than".
ROUND 2 - TARGET	Point to the exact word controlled by the trigger.	"did" -> inspect only the next verb.
ROUND 3 - PROOF	Say why in one sentence.	"Did already marks past, so use V1."
ROUND 4 - NO-ERROR	Before correcting, prove that an error actually exists.	A correct pair is not automatically a wrong sentence.
ROUND 5 - SPEED	Locate the error before fully translating the sentence.	Use trigger -> target, not word-by-word reading.
ERROR LOG	Write Trigger My mistake Correct rule One example.	Keep recurring mistakes visible.

REVISION ORDER: PAIRS -> VERB FORMS -> SVA -> TENSE -> NOUNS -> TO/PREPOSITION -> INVERSION/SUBJUNCTIVE -> MIXED TEST

EXAM CHECKLIST

☐ I saw the trigger.

☐ I identified what it controls.

☐ I checked the exact A/B/C/D chunk.

☐ I proved the error instead of guessing.

☐ I changed only the faulty unit.

☐ I re-read once.

5-ROUND SPEED LOOP

R1 -> recognize trigger

R2 -> point to target

R3 -> say why

R4 -> prove no-error option

R5 -> beat full-sentence reading

ERROR LOG -> trigger | mistake | rule | example

RECOGNIZE

what to notice

PROVE

what to inspect

LOG MISTAKE

what to do

10-SECOND SELF-TEST

Today: pair drill [answer: say partners aloud]

Then: 10 mixed PYQs [answer: locate target before translating]

Finish: error log [answer: record only recurring mistakes]